

Tibet - The five Principle Spiritual Traditions

Tradition has it that Tibet is the Land of Avalokiteshvara, the Bodhisattva of compassion, and the Tibetan people are his descendants thru his mating with an ogress, an emanation of the goddess Tara. Avalokiteshvara was an ape at the time.

In 127 BCE an Indian King named Rupati fled over the Himalayas and was enthroned as king in Tibet by 12 Bon wise priests. The Tibetans evolved a distinct but simple civilization based on the inter dependence of man and nature.

BON was the indigenous religion and the oldest in Tibet. Its origin is probably in western Tibet and the counter clock wise swastika and the number 9 are of great significance. Tonpa Shenrab, the founder, is said to have studied at the feet of a god of compassion and then spread the doctrine in order to help beings immersed in an ocean of misery and suffering.

There are two types of doctrines taught by Tonpa Shenrab. First, the Four Portals and One treasury: The White water, dealing with secret matters; the Black Water concerning narratives, magic, funeral rites and ransom rituals; The Land of Phan doctrine which contains monastic rules and philosophical expositions; the Divine Guide which is the Great Perfection teachings; and finally the Treasury which comprises the essential aspects of all the four portals.

The second classification is the NINE WAYS OF BON which include : the way of prediction (astrology, ritual and prognostication); the way of the visual world (psychophysical universe, way of illusion); Way of existence (funeral and death rituals); Way of a Monk (monastic rules), Way of primordial sound (more advanced way of enlightenment); Way of primordial shen (guidelines for seeking

true tantric master and the spiritual commitments that bind a disciple to Way of Supreme Doctrine (doctrine of the great perfection).

These nine have further subdivisions which are contained in the Bon Canon comprising more than two hundred volumes classified under four sections including Sutras (wisdom teachings), tantras and knowledge. The canon also deals with rituals, arts and crafts, logic, medicine, poetry, and narrative.

With the coming of Buddhism in the late 2nd century CE Bon was discouraged and Buddhism encouraged. However, it never died out and more than three hundred Bon monasteries were established before the coming of the Chinese in 1959. With the exile to India, the Dalai Lama encouraged the establishment of a monastery in India where now complete training in the Bon Philosophy, monastic discipline, ritual and religious dance as well as grammar, astrology and poetry and modern education are available.

There are a total of 14 Bon monasteries in India and Nepal to further strengthen Bon religious activities and to present its doctrine to the outside world. The Dalai Lama has stressed the importance of preserving the Bon tradition as representing the indigenous source of Tibetan culture, and acknowledging the major role it has had in shaping Tibet's unique identity..

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THE FOUR BUDDHIST SCHOOLS

Buddhism was first introduced in 173 CE and was gradually assimilated, disseminated and finally integrated in to the Tibetan way of life due to the efforts of of various kings. The Tibetan script was modled on Sanskrit, learned in India, and the Buddha's teachings were then propogated and translated into Tibetan by many Indian scholars brought in for that purpose.

This era of religious kings came to an end and for some time the Buddha's teachings were not supported, monasteries were emptied and monks made to disrobe, often being recruited into the army. Tibet entered a dark age.

Revival took place when 2 chinese monks gave full ordination to some of the Tibetan community and marked a revival of the Tibetan monastic community. With the arrival of other teachers, Buddhism was revived with the building of monasteries and temples and teaching the doctrine. The four great schools of Tibetan Buddhism were introduced from the time period of the 9th century on.

The third Dalai Lama, Sonam Gyatso (1543-1588), strengthened Tibet's political prospects when he broughjt the Mongols back to Buddhism because of a visit to Mongolia in 1578. He was invited by Altan Khan who gave him the title "Dalai Lama" meaning "ocean of wisdom". The fourth Dalai Lama was born to a mongolian family but was taken to Tibet to be educated. It was the 5th Dalai Lama in the 17th century who founded the government that still functions today under the 14th Dalai Lama.

In 1959, with the acceleration of Chinese aggression in Tibet the Dalai Lama fled to India. He set up a government in exile to take care of education, culture, settlements, monasteries and politics. Of the 6000 monasteries in Tibet, most were destroyed by the Chinese. In exile more than 200 monasteries and nunneries have been reestablished in India, Nepal and Bhutan.

TANTRIC BUDDHISM AND LAMAISM

The form of Buddhism which came from North India was what is known as tantric. Tantra comes from the non-aryan, non Brahmin Indian background and could go back to well before the Aryan invasions. It was not endorsed by the Brahmin priests.

The idea is that it is that thru secret and radical practices one can achieve mokse or Nirvana (depending on if your a Hindu or Buddhist). While the orthodox see occult powers as impediments to liberation, Tantrics court them as proof of progress. Tantrics also cultivate the sensuous elements in their psychic makeups.

In Tibet the eroticized version of yoga is synonymous with the "diamond vehicle" or Vajrayana school. This came to Tibet in the 7th century CE tho all three paths are taught in Tibet, the Hinyana, Mahayana and Vajrayana schools. The word Vajra means both thunderbolt and diamond. the emphasis is on meditation and the idea is that one can be enlightened suddenly, like a thunderbolt, and that like the diamond ultimate reality is impenetratable and tho it can destroy all other things, in itself is indestructable.

Tantric doctrines are passed on from master to student in secret language intelligible only to the initiated. Mandalas depicted an elaborate cosmology with the 5 Buddhas and their female partners at the center. Encircling them are five Bodhisattvas and thier female counterparts. These are surrounded by other figures. All these are interpreted as emanations from the Adi Buddha, the absolute.

These rituals were to be enacted mentally, not physically and the yogi should arrive at the idea that all that exists is consciousness. Thus, there is no fundamental difference between Samsara (rebirth/redeath) and Nirvana (bliss), or any other opposites. Enlightenment itself is a realization of the unity of all polarities such as self/other, sacred/profane and male/female.

LAMAS:

The unique thing about this form of Buddhism, found not only in Tibet but also Nepal, Bhuten and possibly a couple other asian countries, is the idea of how reincarnation takes place for the most highly spiritual and learned monks. Not all monks are lamas but only those who are considered to be Bodhisattvas, ie, Buddhas to be who have attained to Nirvana but have chosen to return over and over until all sentient beings are able to reach nirvana.

Unlike the Mahayana ideal of the Boddhisatvas who rule over a paradise (western, eastern, northern, etc.) in the "Pure Land" schools, it is believed that these Bodhisatvas come back in the flesh over and over. These are the persons termed Lamas in this tradition.

The great founders of the four schools and all those who have attained enlightenment in those schools, are believed to be reincarnated within 49 days after their death. Usually the dying lama will give an idea where he (or she ins some cases) will be reborn so that three or four years after their "death" the monks of their school will seek them out and apply severel tests to see if this child will recognize people, objects, etc. that they had in their previous life.

If the child passes the tests, then they are brought for training to the monastery where they had lived and start thru the monastic schooling again. The 14th Dalai lama, Tensing Gyatso, was born in 1936 and discovered when he was 3. At age 4 he was taken to Lhaşa. Parents of a reincarnated lama are considered a holy family in a real sense.

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THE NYINGMA TRADITION is the oldest of the 4 Buddhist schools beginning with an Indian adept who came to Tibet in 817 CE at the invitation of the king in order to help make a climate compatible for the re-spreading of Buddhism. He established a monastery where the texts that would make up Tibet's vast Buddhist literature were first translated.

He spread Tantric teachings so that although the study of logic and Buddhist philosophy was not yet prevalent, the practice of tantra in extreme secrecy was much favored.

The Nyingma tradition divides the entire Buddhist teachings into nine vehicles. The Three common vehicles comprising the Hearer, solitary realizer, and Bodhisattva vehicles dealing with the sutras and their teachings. There are three outer Tantras which involve proper external behaviour, physical and verbal conduct aimed at purification and simple visualization practice. Yoga tantra which is aimed at developing the inner psychophysical vitality.

The three inner most tantras are found only in this school while the other six are found in all the buddhist schools. The Inner tantras try to eliminate the ordinary level of perception and attachment thru sacred vision, then the completion stage in which the vajra (diamond) body is used as a means to actualize primordial awareness. Finally, the last stage when all emphasis is directed toward the yogi transcending all ordinary time, activity and experience.

Nyingmapas did not become institutionalized until much later in their history. From the 15th century onwards, great monastic universities were built. There have been four monastic institutions re-established in exile.

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THE SAKYA TRADITION is closely bound up with an ancestral lineage which is believed to be derived from celestial beings. It goes back to the 11th century. It also traces itself to an Indian yogi and its first monastery was built in central Tibet and was named Sakya, or Grey Earth monastery so the school took its name from the location of this monastery.

They study both Buddhist and non-Buddhist philosophy, logic, sanskrit, poetry, astrology and art. One of the early lamas was invited by Kublai Khan to Mongolia where he invented a new script in which to write the Mongolian language. Kublai Khan was so impressed by the lama's performance that he declared Buddhism the state religion of Mongolia and presented him the rule of three provinces of Tibet.

The current Lama, Kunga Theckchen Rinpochey (b. 1945) lives in India where succession to the position of head of the Sakya tradition has been hereditary since the earliest Lama.

There are a number of divisions within the tradition but the central teaching and practice is called "the Path and its Fruits". The philosophical viewpoint expressed in this teaching is the inseparability of samsara and nirvana. According to this, an individual cannot attain Nirvana or peace by abandoning samsara or cyclic existence, because the mind is the root of both samsara and nirvana. When obscured, it takes the form of samsara and when freed of obstructions it is Nirvana. Hence, the reality is that a person must strive through meditation to realize their inseparability.

The Sakya have re-established 4 monasteries in India and one in Nepal to continue their teachings.

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THE KAGYU TRADITION comes from Nepal and India and dates back also to the 11th century CE. It involves tantric teaching which concerns the illusory body and Consciousness transference, dreams, clear light, and Inner heat. The original source was Buddha Vajradhara or the Diamond way.

The foremost disciple was Milarepa (1040-1123) the most celebrated and accomplished of Tibet's tantric yogis, who achieved the ultimate goal of enlightenment in one lifetime.

There are many sub-schools and one in particular, the Karma Kagyu, has remained strong and successful due in large part to the presence of an unbroken line of reincarnations of the founder. However, the last reincarnation died in 1981 and has not yet (I don't think) been found again yet.

The tradition has re-established its headquarters in India and has developed hundreds of centers throughout the world. In the absence of the lamas incarnation four high lamas who were his disciples are acting as regents.

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The main thrust of this schools teaching is aimed at direct understanding of the real nature of the mind. The approach differs between the various Kagyu schools but the six yogas of tantric practice to train monks. this training of monks consists mainly of the study of the perfection of wisdom, valid cognition, discipline and phenomenology.

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THE GEŁUG TRADITION is the last of these four Buddhist schools founded in the 15th century by Je Tsongkhapa. At the age of three he received full-fledged lay ordination. As a young man he frequently had visions of meditational deities with whom he could communicate to settle his questions about profound aspects of the teachings.

He studied with over 100 teachers and practiced extensively, teaching thousands of disciples. He wrote a collection comprising 18 volumes, containing hundreds of titles relating to all aspects of Buddhist teachings.

It is from this Gelug school that the Dalai Lamas come. The first Dalai Lama, Gyalwa Gendun Drup, founded a monastery at Shigatse in 1447, which was to become the seat of the successive Panchen Lamas. It originally had 4 colleges.

At its peak there were more than 5000 monks in each of the monastic universities around Lhasa. Young men would travel from all three regions of Tibet to enroll at these monastic universities as monks in order to receive an education and spiritual training.

The Gelug tradition lays special emphasis on the place of ethics, as expressed thru monastic discipline, as the ideal basis for religious education and practice. Consequently, the great majority of Gelugpa lamas are monks and the master who is a layman is a rarity.

The Gelug tradition regards sound scholarship as a prerequisite for constructive meditation. The curriculum covers the five major topics: The perfection of Wisdom, philosophy of the Middle Way, Valid cognition, Phenomenology and monastic discipline. These are studied meticulously by the dialectical method using Indian texts as well as Indian and Tibetan commentaries and takes 15 to 20 years to complete training. There are three levels of degrees given and a monk who has completed the highest degree is respected as being a fully qualified and authoritative spiritual master worthy of devotion and esteem.

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BUDDHISM MAHAYANA BUDDHISM

The Dorje Shugden Controversy

Destroying Tibetan Buddhism in Order to Save It?

Ads Crystal Healing Reincarnation Of Buddhism Your Reincarnation Chakra Healing Mindfulness Meditation

I have hesitated to weigh in on the Shugden controversy because I practice Zen Buddhism, and the Shugden controversy involves aspects of Tibetan Buddhism that are mystifying even to other Buddhists. But the continuing demonstrations against His Holiness the Dalai Lama need to be explained, so I will do the best I can. Dorje Shugden is an iconic character from Tibetan mythology. Much of

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Tibetan iconography features deities and heavenly beings representing the dharma or an energy or function of enlightenment, such as compassion. In tantric Buddhist practice (which is not limited to Tibetan Buddhism), meditation, chants, and other practices that focus on these iconic characters cause the energy or function they represent to arise in the practitioner and become manifest. Thus, these beings are best understood as archetypes.

The Tibetan Distinction

Tibetan Buddhism, with its elaborate schema of who is a

consort, reincarnation or wrathful manifestation of whom, does seem to see the iconic characters as a bit more real and solid than do other Buddhists. And this seems out of keeping with Buddhism's ~~non-theistic nature~~. As Mike Wilson explains in this very insightful essay, "The Tibetan Buddhist view of the Shugden controversy" the Tibetans consider all phenomena to be creations of mind. This is a teaching based on a philosophy

called Yogachara, and it is found

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in many schools of Mahayana

Buddhism, not just Tibetan

Buddhism..The Tibetans reason
that if people and other
phenomena are creations of
mind, and gods and demons are
also creations of mind, then the
gods and demons are no more

or less real than fish, birds and people. Thus, the heavenly beings are not just
archetypes, but "real," although empty of inherent existence. This interpretation
is, ~~seems to be~~ ^{seems to be} unique to Tibetan Buddhism.

Who Is Dorje Shugden?

Dorje Shugden is a ~~dharmapala~~ ^{dharmapala} or dharma protector, who entered Tibetan
mythology about three centuries ago. There are various explanations of exactly
who he is, but his devotees consider him to be an emanation of ~~Manjushri~~ ^{Manjushri}
~~Bodhisattva~~ ^{Bodhisattva} the Bodhisattva of Wisdom.. See "The Dalai Lama's Sixth Avenue" for
historical background on Dorje Shugden and the sect that supports him. See the
~~Western Shugden Society~~ ^{Western Shugden Society} for more explanation from the perspective of
Shugden followers.

Why Is This a Big Deal?

In "The Shuk-Den Affair: Origins of a Controversy," academic Georges Dreyfus
details the origins and development of the Shugden mythology, and why ~~His~~ ^{His}
~~Holiness~~ the Dalai Lama came to object to it in the mid-1970s. To violently
encapsulate a very complicated story, the Shugden controversy has deep roots
in an old dispute about the authority of the Dalai Lama. Shugden veneration also
has a history of stirring up staunchly sectarian, even fundamentalist, passions
among its followers, setting schools of Tibetan Buddhism against each
other.. On several occasions, ~~His Holiness~~ ^{The Dalai Lama} has stated these reasons for
discouraging Shugden veneration:

- **Shugden worship encourages sectarian enmity.** ~~His Holiness~~ ^{The Dalai Lama} wants to
promote non-sectarianism and tolerance among the four major schools and
various sects of Tibetan Buddhism. Loyalty to Shugden is counterproductive
to this goal.
- **Shugden worship is not Buddhism.** This is obviously true. Buddhism is not
a spirit-worship religion.
- **Shugden worship is bad for Tibet.** Among other things, it is alleged that the
Shugden cult, which goes about protesting the Dalai Lama wherever he
speaks publicly, is being supported by the government of China. ~~✓~~

~~Mike Wilson's "Shugden: A History of the Controversy" is helpful for understanding the controversy.~~

Discrimination?

~~According to Mike Wilson, cited above,~~ [✓] Shugden devotees
responsible for the ritualistic murders of three anti-Shugden
Dharmasala in 1997. At the same time, the Shugden sect
that it is the victim of religious discrimination, because the

5) The whole fuss would have died down long ago except for the fact that the "hard-
line" operatives of the "United Front Work Department" of the People's Republic of
China, the agency in charge of dealing with China's "minority nationalities," sees the
cult as a potential wedge they hope to drive between the Dalai Lama and his people
and between him and world opinion. They therefore fund the leaders of the cult in
Tibet, Mongolia, India and the West, and provide them the means to carry on their
expensive propaganda campaigns. Evidence for this is very plain on the surface. For
example, the so-called "Panchen Lama" reincarnation, whom the Communist party
chiefs appointed after abducting and disappearing the five year old boy properly
chosen in the traditional way by a committee of his monastery with approval of the
Dalai Lama, is shown on the internet in various photographs sitting in front of a large
icon of Dolgyal Shugden, as a sign of aggressive defiance of the Dalai Lama. The
obvious fact is that the clearly stated purpose of the cult and the United Front agency
of the PRC is to try to prove to the world that the Dalai Lama is not as nice as we all
think, but is a bad, even "evil," person.

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permit observance of Shugden devotion..The answer for the Shugden followers is obvious -- declare independence from all Tibetan Buddhist institutions and *start your own sect*. There is probably some reason why this isn't an acceptable solution for them, but ~~I don't know~~ *is unknown*

Conclusion

~~Shugden followers will complain that this article presents a one-sided view. Well, yes, indeed, and that one side is that Buddhism is not a spirit worship religion. At a time when Buddhism is still being introduced to the West, it is damaging to all schools of Buddhism to be confused with spirit worship. Tibetan Buddhism is being systematically flushed out of Tibet by the government of China. As Tibetan Buddhism scatters, disembodied, around the globe, ~~the~~ ~~Holiness~~ the Dalai Lama is struggling to maintain some cohesion and integrity within it. The Shugden controversy clearly is weakening that effort.~~

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OUTLINE OF EARLY CHINESE HISTORY

(Dates and entries before 841 B.C. are traditional)

B.C.	Dynasty	
2852		
2737		Culture Heroes {
2697		Shen Nung, inventor of agriculture, commerce.
		Yellow Emperor.
2357		
2255		Sage Kings {
2205		Yao.
1818		Shun.
1766		
[c. 1300]	Hsia Dynasty	Yü, virtuous founder of dynasty.
1154		Chieh, degenerate terminator of dynasty.
	Shang or Yin Dynasty	King T'ang, virtuous founder of dynasty.
		[Beginning of archeological evidence.]
		Chou, degenerate terminator of dynasty.

	Three Dynasties		
1122			King Wen, virtuous founder of dynasty.
1115			King Wu, virtuous founder of dynasty.
878			King Ch'eng, virtuous founder of dynasty.
781			(Duke of Chou, regent to King Ch'eng)
771			King Li.
722			King Yu.
551			Spring and Autumn period (722-481).
403			Period of the "hundred philosophers" (551-c. 233): Confucius, Mo Tzu, Lao Tzu (?), Mencius, Chuang Tzu, Hui Shih, Shang Yang, Kung-sun Lung, Hsün Tzu, Han Fei Tzu.
4th to 3d cent.			
249			Warring States period (403-221).
221			Extensive wall-building and waterworks by Ch'in and other states.
214			Lü Pu-wei, prime minister of Ch'in.
	Ch'in Dynasty		The First Emperor; Li Ssu, prime minister.
	(221-207 B.C.)		The Great Wall completed.